abilities. But living in India over the last decade, after thirty-four years based abroad, has taught me I was wrong. As an eighteen-year-old blogger, Tejaswini Tabhane, pointed out recently, 'A Brahmin's caste pride comes with humiliation for other castes'. Caste, she writes, 'is both the base and superstructure of Indian society and both the relations of power as well as the forces of production are mediated through it. Blindness to caste does not take away the social, political and economical privileges one gets because of one's "accident of birth" in a particular ("upper") caste.' In her words, anyone belonging to a hierarchically privileged caste 'is bound to get the advantages of his caste location, willingly or unwillingly, consciously or unconsciously. Caste governs the distribution of resources and opportunities in Indian society. Caste is very much present in your life even if it is not directly visible to you because your social and economic capital is a production of your caste only.'[7]

I have to concede she is right. And that makes her admonition strike home: 'To be born in a privileged caste is not anyone's fault but to refuse to even acknowledge "unearned benefits" accruing due to one's caste and thereby claiming that the very mechanism that enforces them is absent in one's life is not right.' On the other hand, 'For the people belonging to the marginalised lower strata of this system, caste is about humiliation, deprivation, oppression and imposed identity.'

Caste blindness, in other words, is itself an affectation available only to the privileged; the 'lower' castes cannot afford to be indifferent to caste. Parallels are sought to be drawn to debates over race-blind policies in the West, but these are inexact: race, after all, is visible, whereas caste is not, which makes it genuinely possible to be caste-blind in one's social and personal relations in a way that is not feasible in multi-race contexts (a white person cannot credibly say, 'I didn't realise he was black', least of all when a white employer rejects a black applicant's job application, but an upper-caste Hindu can plausibly claim, 'I didn't know she was a Dalit'). Still, the temper of the times demands consciousness of caste and positive compensatory action for its disabilities, rather than blindness to it. Jawaharlal Nehru had hoped caste would disappear from India's